

Mullah & the Mandarin

The blood in Tehran and Urumqi (we still need jackboots to introduce us to the mysteries of geography) has spoiled the 20th anniversary celebrations of 1989, Europe's *annus mirabilis*. It's also a reminder, a savage one at that: freedom continues to be a permanent struggle, no matter the Soviet empire, the Berlin Wall, Erich Honecker and Wojciech Jaruzelski are archival items missed by the likes of Prakash Karat. Twenty years ago, the Big Lie of ideology was swept aside as people overcame fear and the streets—from Budapest to Prague to Warsaw to Leipzig—erupted in freedom. History even gave a beautiful adjective to revolution then: "velvet". Today, Iran and China, two sanguineous tyrannies with their own cultural exceptionalism, tell us why we are fools in party mode. The mullah and the mandarin tell us how gullible we are, we the romantics swayed by the first fragile tableau of freedom. In Tehran, what lifted the veil of the Islamic Ruritania was the mockery of an election and its dubious winner—the nutty, Holocaust-denying President Mahmoud Ahmadinejad. The young and the restless needed a cause and they found one in the defeated (by the system, not the people) candidate Mir Hossein Mousavi, the 'reformer' who is not exactly a Persian Havel but very much a product of the system. What matters is not his political future but the unsolicited martyrdom of Neda Agha Soltan and countless others who are immortalised by YouTube and Twitter. It was a kind of Tiananmen Square all over again as Revolutionary Guards and the Ayatollah's stealth thugs known as Basij cracked down on the dreamers. The Great Islamic Revolution is sustained by blood, fear and, of course, enriched uranium.

Like the People's Republic is kept alive as the Wonder of the East by controlling the conscience of the people. "Be Happy, Keep Quiet" is an old socialist pretence. In the neo-Confucian China, happiness is the state religion, and questions are blasphemous. Totalitarianism is an idyll, writes Milan Kundera. The ethnic bloodlust in Urumqi in

Xinjiang province has shattered the Chinese idyll, and revealed the Oriental beast that lurks behind the glitz of the much rhapsodised marketplace. China is not all about Shanghai and Shenzhen; it's also about the Gulag of the East. The aspirations of the bloodied Uighurs, the Muslim minority in Urumqi, give us a glimpse of the simmering passions beneath the idyll, the 'order' that the mandarins of Zhongnanhai maintain through a ruthless Leninist party apparatus. Prosperity is not an alternative to freedom and in China, the Fifth Modernisation is still an unfinished project in democracy. So let's stop romancing the magic carpet of Persia and the miracle of the Middle Kingdom, ideas that kill freedom.



SIGNPOSTS

DIED: **Nibu Phule**, 79, film and theatre actor and social activist who featured in over 140 Marathi and 12 Hindi movies such as



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Saaransh, Mashaal, Prem Pratigya, Coolie and Duniya.

APPOINTED: **Naresh Gaur** as the Additional Director-General of the Border Security Force. He is the first officer from within the force to be elevated to the post.

APPOINTED: **Pradeep Kumar** as Defence Secretary. He takes over from Vijay Singh. Kumar is presently secretary (Defence Production) in the Ministry of Defence.

WON: By **Virdhawal Khade** (below), the 50m freestyle gold medal and a silver in the 50m butterfly at the International Schwimmfest in Darmstadt, Germany. **Sandeep Sejwal** bagged a silver in the 50m breaststroke.



SAURABH SINGH

